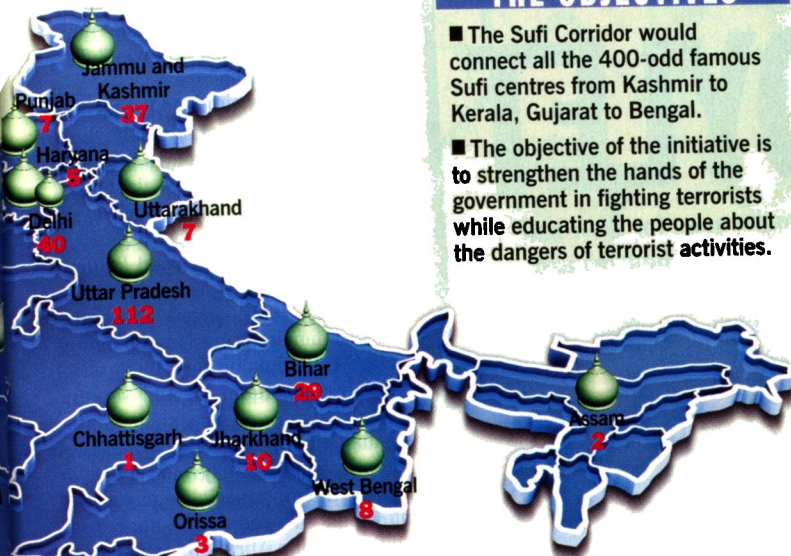


THE OBJECTIVES

■ The Sufi Corridor would connect all the 400-odd famous Sufi centres from Kashmir to Kerala, Gujarat to Bengal.

■ The objective of the initiative is to strengthen the hands of the government in fighting terrorists while educating the people about the dangers of terrorist activities.



Uttar Pradesh was rocked by serial bomb blasts in Lucknow, Faizabad and Varanasi civil courts. These blasts, once again, coincided with the Friday prayers and claimed 14 lives. Shaken by these incidents, Sufis decided to come out of their 'hujras' (meditation chambers or prayer cells) to play the role they have historically played in spreading the message of Islam and creating a composite culture in India.

The Sufis, led by Jilani Baba, set up the Khwaja Gharib Nawaz Council (now renamed as the Sufi Federation of India) to bring all Sufis on a single platform and draw a road-map to unite Hindus and Muslims against the dangers of terrorism. Prominent Sufi leaders from all across the country are part of the initiative. The Sufis and their followers plan to set out on a spiritual voyage asking the people to be aware of their religious and civic duty in strengthening society to identify and condemn terrorist activities which are the handiwork of only a handful of misguided and mischievous elements and are totally against the spirit of Islam. By October this year a chain of Sufi shrines would be created which would in turn create a ring of followers who would carry the message of peace and unity. These local-level rings would connect with each other to form a larger, nationwide chain the sole aim of which

would be to promote peace and brotherhood among faiths. The progress of the corridor would be reviewed and the future course of action would be worked out at a conference in Bangalore in October this year. Sufis say this approach would work at two levels—it would help the government and its agencies counter terrorism and it would create awareness among the people about the larger threat posed by terrorist groups.

This concept of Sufi Corridor is also seen as the next step to the setting up of the Sufi University that was aimed at reviving the concept of mysticism. Though most of the orthodox schools of Islamic thought have rejected Sufism as un-Islamic, their message and following has grown, cutting across regions and faiths. Apart from their numbers—the Sufi Foundation of India estimates there are over 10 crore Sufi followers in the country—the greatest contribution of Muslim Sufi saints is the creation of a composite culture in India dating back to the 13th century with the arrival of

Khwaja Moinuddin Chishti at Ajmer Sharif. This helped blunt the edge of Hindu-Muslim prejudices by forging solidarity and brotherhood among these two communities.

The movement has been supported by key Hindu religious leaders. "Sants follow the path of peace, love and non-violence. So the campaign launched by Sufis against terrorism must be supported by all. It might help trace the roots of terrorism and destroy it forever. All the saints and sadhus of Ayodhya support this initiative," says Acharya Satyendra Das, chief priest of Ram Janmabhoomi, Ayodhya. However, Maulana Khalid Rasheed, president, Ulema Council of India and member, All India Muslim Personal Law Board, remains sceptical. "Some Muslim leaders and scholars have started a wrong trend to claim that they are against terrorism. This creates suspicion that the community is feeling guilty. Terrorism has nothing to do with any religion. We saw 'terrorism' when the Babri Masjid was destroyed. There is Maoist terrorism across the country. There is Israeli terrorism in Palestine.

Iraq also faces terrorism. The movement will succeed only when Hindus and Muslims campaign together," says Rasheed.

This is what actually Sufis are striving to achieve—to bring together the followers of all religions in their collective fight against terrorism. And not everyone subscribes to Rasheed's reservations. "We know there is no bigger traitor than the one who tries to question the faith of the Islamic community. Such protests by the community can be a fitting reply to the miscreants, something that even the Government cannot

give," says Union Minister of State for Home Sriprakash Jaiswal.

Despite the sceptics, any initiative against terrorism is to be welcomed, especially when it is undertaken by Muslims and, in particular Sufis, who ultimately have the right credentials to promote peace.



"Sufi saints live in people's hearts while invaders have been consigned to history."

MAULANA
JILANI ASHRAF,
SUFİ LEADER